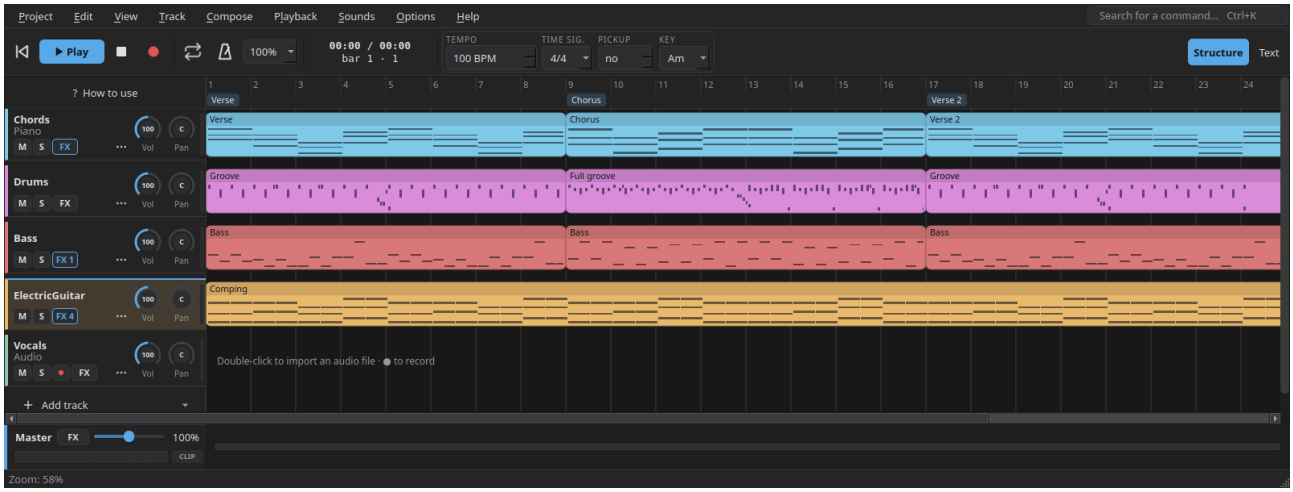
SoundText

From the first chord to the WAV

A hands-on guide to building a song from start to finish:
chords, drums, bass, guitar, vocals, effects, amplifier, plugins, mastering and audio export



SoundText 1.14 · edition of 2026-11-03

Contents

1. What we will build 3
2. Before you start 4
3. The project and the window 5
4. The chords: the progression 6
5. Drums and bass 7
6. The electric guitar 9
7. The melody: written, played or recorded 10
8. Listen, fix, balance 11
9. Track effects 12
10. The guitar amplifier 14
11. Mastering 16
12. Exporting the WAV 17
13. Studio sounds with other programs 18
14. VST3 and LV2 plugins, SFZ instruments 19
15. The menu map (SoundText 1.14) 20
16. Checklist and common problems 21

1. What we will build

In this guide we build a complete song step by step and turn it into a **WAV** audio file, ready to play anywhere, send to a friend or upload online. We will use almost everything SoundText offers: the generators, writing notes by hand, recording, the mixer, effects, the guitar amplifier and mastering.

The example song is called **“My first song”**:

Item	Choice
Key	A minor (Am)
Tempo and meter	100 BPM, 4/4
Form	Verse (8 bars) → Chorus (8 bars) → Verse 2 (8 bars)
Tracks	Chords (piano), Drums, Bass, Electric guitar through an amplifier, Vocals (recorded) or a written melody
Result	A 48 kHz / 24-bit WAV file, with effects and mastering

The route at a glance:

Step	What you do	Chapter
1	Install SoundText and get the sounds	2
2	Create the project: tempo, meter, key, save	3
3	Write the chord progression (verse and chorus)	4
4	Add drums and bass, or arrange everything at once	5
5	Add the electric guitar	6
6	Melody: write it, play it or record your voice	7
7	Listen, fix the form, balance the levels	8
8	Track effects	9
9	Amplifier or NAM profile on the guitar	10
10	Master the final mix	11
11	Export the WAV	12
12	Optional: studio sounds with other programs (re-amping)	13
13	Optional: VST3 and LV2 plugins, SFZ instruments	14

Three useful things from the start

You don't have to follow everything to the letter: each chapter stands on its own. If you already have a song, jump straight to effects (chapter 9) or export (chapter 12).

Any command can also be found with **Ctrl+K** (**Search for a command...**): type what you want to do (“export”, “record”, “bass”...) and press Enter.

Every step is also shown in the video tutorial series (English, with subtitles in Italian, French and Spanish): youtube.com/playlist?list=PLbVfXEqrD3P4

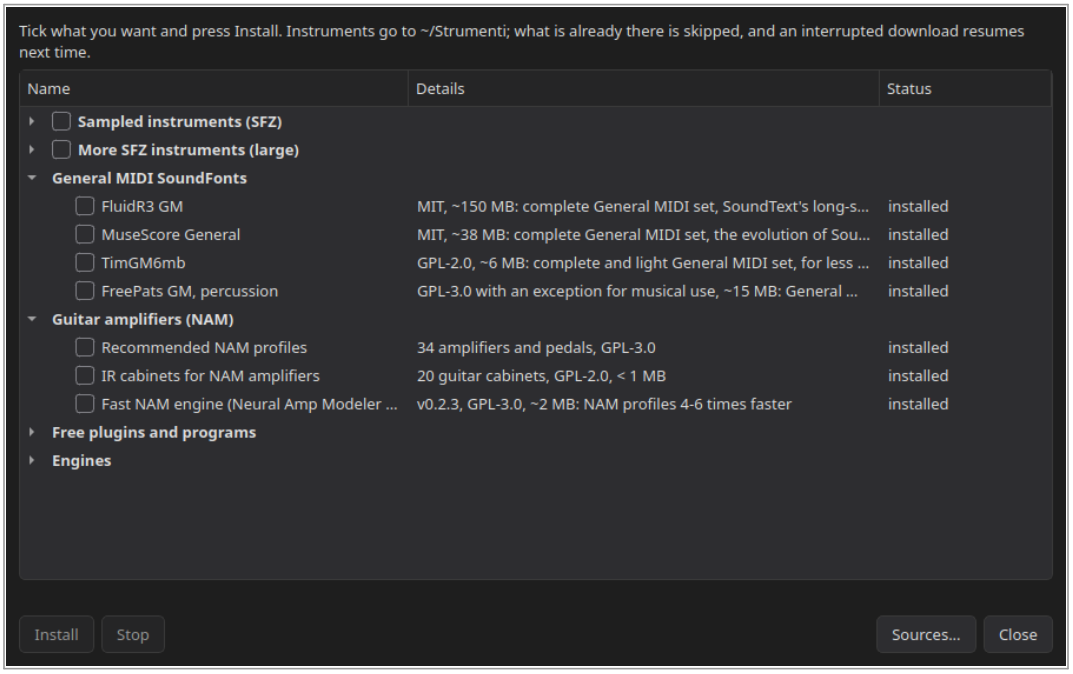
2. Before you start

To install SoundText, follow the README on GitHub (github.com/openssound/soundtext) or episode 1 of the videos: on Linux there are the AppImage, the portable package and the install script; on Windows and macOS the installer or the script.

The sounds

SoundText plays written tracks (notes and chords) with a General MIDI **SoundFont**, an **.sf2** or **.sf3** file holding the instrument sounds. It isn't bundled: at first start, if it can't find one, SoundText offers to download **FluidR3 GM** (free, about 150 MB).

1. Answer **Yes**: **Sounds → Download and install...** opens with FluidR3 GM already ticked. Press **Install** and wait for the download to finish.
2. If you already have a SoundFont, pick it with **Sounds → SoundFont → Choose SoundFont (.sf2/.sf3)...**. The choice is remembered.
3. To check: **Project → Open example...**, pick an example and press **Play**.



“Download and install”: SoundFonts, SFZ sampled instruments, NAM profiles and cabinet IRs for the guitar, free plugins and engines, all from one window.

The same window downloads everything else we will use: **SFZ sampled instruments** (chapter 14), **NAM profiles** and **cabinet IRs** for the amplifier (chapter 10), **free plugins** and the engine of the built-in SFZ instrument. Anything already installed is skipped, and an interrupted download resumes next time.

Tip

Use **headphones** or decent speakers: effects (especially reverb, compressor and limiter) are hard to judge on laptop speakers.

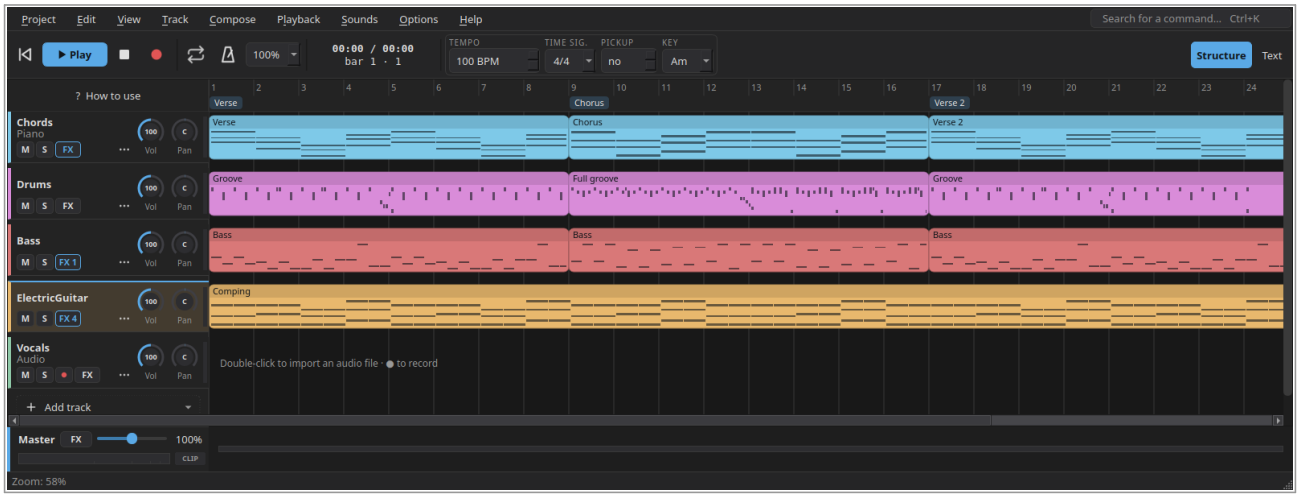
The interface language is set in **Options → Language** (English, Italian, French, Spanish), the theme in **Options → Theme**.

3. The project and the window

1. **Project → New** (**Ctrl+N**).
2. In the command bar, the **Tempo / Time sig. / Pickup / Key** box: set **100 BPM**, **4/4** and **Am**. The generators will suggest that key.
3. Save right away: **Project → Save** (**Ctrl+S**), for example as **My_first_song.st**.
4. Make sure you are in the **Structure** view (button at the top right; it's the starting view).

Tip

Saving early matters: recordings and imported audio files go into the **My_first_song_audio/** folder next to the .st file. From here on press **Ctrl+S** now and then, and remember that **Ctrl+Z** undoes any change. If the program closes unexpectedly, it offers to recover your unsaved work at the next start.



The Structure view of the finished song: one row per track, the boxes (Verse, Chorus, Verse 2) along the timeline, the track headers on the left and the Master row at the bottom.

The parts of the window

- **Command bar**: back to start, **Play**/Pause (**Space** or F5), Stop (F6), ● Record, A-B loop, metronome and listening speed; the display with elapsed time and bar; tempo, meter, pickup and key; the **Structure** and **Text** views; on the right **Search for a command...**.
- **Track headers** (left): name and instrument, **M** (Mute), **S** (Solo), ● to record (audio tracks), **FX** (effects), the **⋯** menu with every track action and two knobs: **Vol** and **Pan**.
- **Rows of boxes**: each box is a named piece of music. Drag it along the timeline, double-click to open it, right-click for every action (listen, duplicate, rename, transpose,

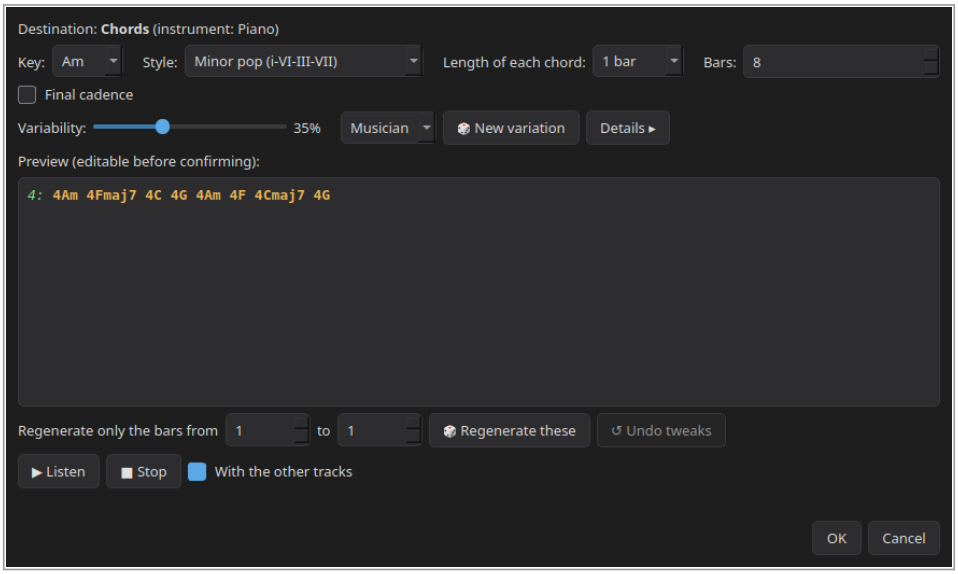
cut/copy/paste, delete).

- **Ruler** at the top, with the section names: click to move the playhead (the next Play starts there).
- **Master row** at the bottom: the master **FX** button, the overall volume, the level meter with the **CLIP** light; next to it, the progress bar (click to jump).
- **How to use**, above the headers: the shortcuts of the Structure view.

4. The chords: the progression

The chords are what bass and guitar lean on, so we start here. SoundText writes them for you from a style.

1. Click **+ Add track** (below the last header) and, in the **Generate a track** section, choose **Chord progression...**
2. In the dialog: **Key** Am (already suggested), **Style Minor pop (i-VI-III-VII)**, **Length of each chord** 1 bar, **Bars** 8.
3. Press **▶ Listen**. If you don't like it press **New variation**, or change the style.
4. Press **OK**: the **Chords** track (piano) appears with an 8-bar box.
5. Right-click the box → **Rename...** → “Verse”.



The progression dialog: style, chord length, bars, variability and the editable preview. “Listen” plays the result before you confirm.

The chorus

1. Right-click the **Chords** track name → **Generate chord progression in this track...**
2. Style **Epic minor (i-VI-VII-i)**, 8 bars, **OK**: the new box goes right after the verse. Rename it “Chorus”.
3. Select the “Verse” box and press **Ctrl+D** (Duplicate): the copy goes into the first free space, after the chorus. Rename it “Verse 2”.

> **Names that matter**
> Use names like Intro, Verse, Pre-chorus, Chorus, Bridge, Outro: “Arrange the song” (chapter 5) reads each section's intensity from them.

Variability, cadence and preview

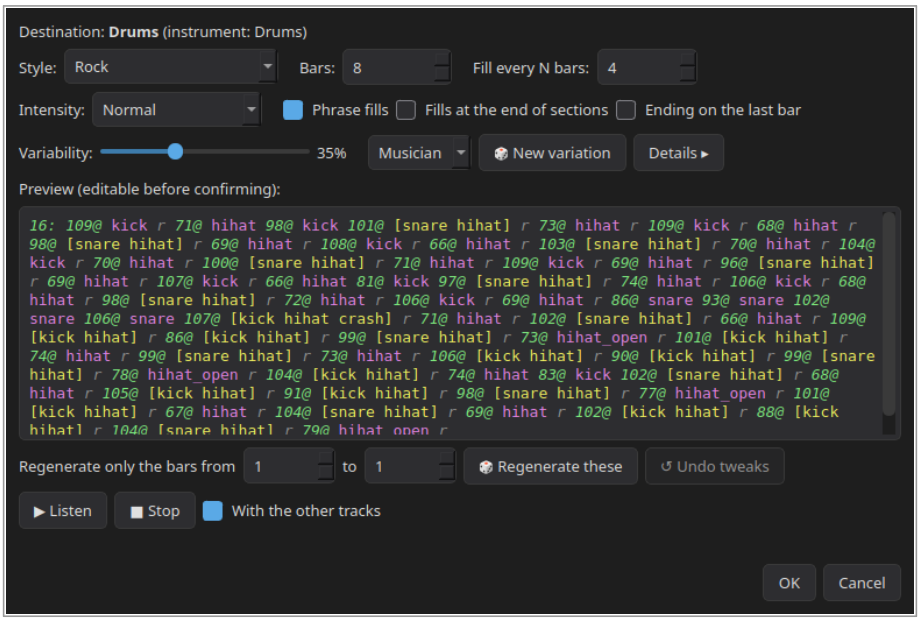
At 0% the style is written as is; raising **Variability** brings richer chords (sevenths, sus), secondary dominants and substitutions. The presets **Faithful**, **Musician** and **Creative** are good starting points. **Final cadence** ends the progression on the tonic. You can edit the preview text by hand before pressing OK, and **Regenerate these** changes only the bars you choose.

> **Tip**
> Want to see what's inside a box? Double-click it: the editor opens with the text, for example `4: 4Am 4F 4C 4G` (a quarter-note grid, each chord lasts 4 quarters = one bar). Chapter 7 explains how to read it.

5. Drums and bass

Drums: light verses, full chorus

1. **+ Add track → Drums...**
2. **Style** Rock, **Bars** 8, **Fill every N bars** 4, **Phrase fills** ticked, **Intensity Light (verse, intro)**. Listen with **With the other tracks** ticked to hear it with the chords, then **OK**.
3. Right-click the **Drums** track name → **Generate drums in this track...**: 8 bars with **Intensity Full (chorus)**: it moves to the ride, plays louder and opens with a crash. The box goes after the first one: rename it “Full groove”.
4. For Verse 2 duplicate the first box (**Ctrl+D**), or generate a new one with **Ending on the last bar** ticked to end the song on a crash.



The drum dialog: style, bars, fills, intensity and variability. The preview is the drum text (kick, snare, hihat...), and you can edit it.

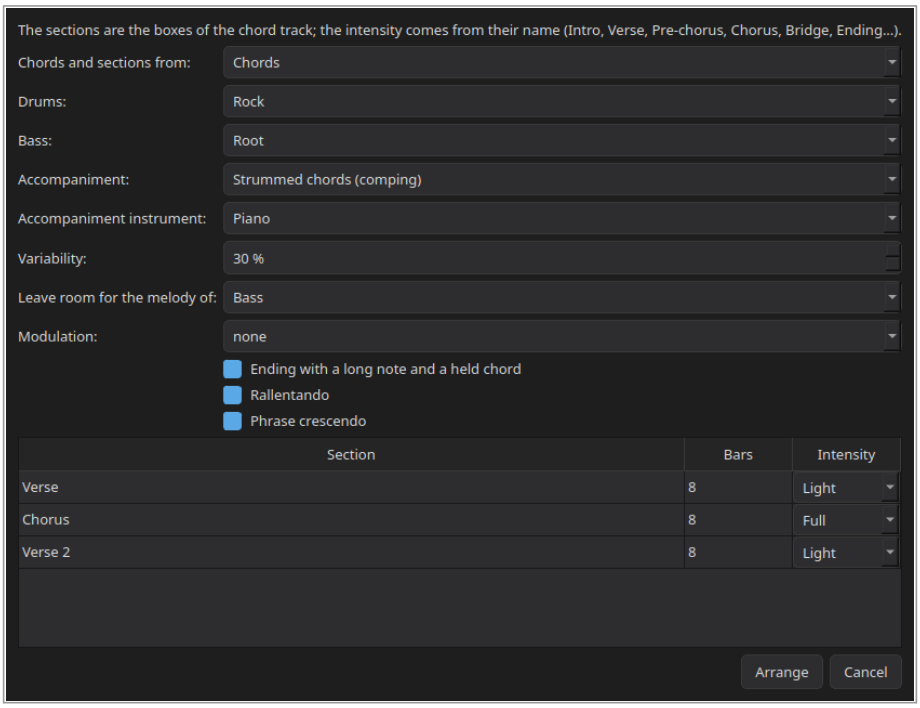
Bass: it follows the chords by itself

1. **+ Add track → Bass from chords...** (available only once the song has a chord track).
2. **Chords from**: Chords. **Style**: **Root/fifth** (simple and solid) or **Octaves** for a busier chorus. **OK**.
3. The bass covers the whole progression: verse, chorus and verse 2.

> **Fine-tuning**
>
> **Regenerate only some bars**: if a bar doesn't work, set “from N to M” below the preview and press **Regenerate these**: only those change.
>
> **Shift+Space** plays only the selected box; **Space** the whole song.

The fast lane: Arrange the song

If your chord track is already split into sections, **Compose → Arrange the song...** writes drums, bass and comping for the whole song in one go, section by section: each section's intensity comes from the box name (light verse, full chorus) and can be changed in the table. Then you refine each box like the ones you generated by hand.



“Arrange the song”: drum, bass and comping styles, and each section's intensity.

6. The electric guitar

To get the most out of the amplifier (chapter 10) you need a **clean** electric guitar sound: SoundText's amplifier will distort it, just like a real guitar plugged into an amp.

Create the instrument

1. **Sounds → Manage instruments... → + New instrument**.
2. **Name in the program**: ElectricGuitar (one word, no spaces).
3. **General MIDI sound** type “clean” and choose **Electric Guitar (clean)**. Octave, range and voicing are filled in for you. **OK**.

> **Watch out**
> Don't pick “Overdriven Guitar” or “Distortion Guitar” if you are going to use the amplifier: you would distort twice, with a muddy, confused sound.

Generate the comping

1. **+ Add track → Accompaniment or riff...** and choose **ElectricGuitar** as the instrument (polyphonic = comping).
2. **Chords from**: Chords. **Style**: **Strummed chords (comping)**. Leave **Close inversions** ticked: the chords move as little as possible, the way a guitarist would play them.
3. ▶ **Listen**, then **OK**. For now it sounds clean: the amplifier comes in chapter 10.

> **Tip**
> A more realistic sound: “Download and install” has the sampled **FreePats clean electric guitar**. Install it together with the built-in SFZ engine and assign it to the track as an SFZ instrument (chapter 14).
>
> Have a real guitar? Create an **audio track** instead and record it through the **INST/Hi-Z** input of your audio interface, without an amp: you record the clean sound, SoundText's amplifier shapes it afterwards, and you can change it any time without re-recording.

7. The melody: written, played or recorded

Route A: write the notes

1. **+ Add track** → **Track with instrument...** (**Ctrl+T**): name “Melody”, instrument Trumpet (or flute, sax, violin...).
2. Double-click the track's row at the start of the verse: the editor of a new box opens.
3. Type the notes (see below), press ▶ **Play** in the editor to hear them, then **OK**.

SoundText notation in five minutes

Write	Means	Example
`c d e f g a b`	Notes	`c e g`
`*n`	Octave of the note	`a*4 c*5`
`#`, `b`	Sharp and flat	`f# eb`
`N:`	Grid: 4 = quarters, 8 = eighths, 16 = sixteenths	`8:`
number in front	Length in grid units	`2c*5` (two eighths)
`r`, `Nr`	Rest	`2r`
`N@`, `mf@`	Note volume (velocity or dynamic)	`90@`, `p@`
`[...]`	Notes together	`[c e g]`
Capital letter	Chord	`Am F C G7`
`N(...)`	Repeat N times	`2(c d e)`

A verse phrase in A minor, in eighths:

```
8: 90@ a*4 c*5 e*5 d*5 2c*5 a*4 2r
8: 100@ e*5 e*5 d*5 c*5 4a*4 4r
```

And a phrase that grows louder (`p@ >> ... f@` is a crescendo):

```
4: p@ >> a*4 c*5 e*5 f@ 4e*5
```

The editor's colors show how the program reads the text (notes, chords, rests...), mistakes are flagged bar by bar before you confirm, and autocomplete suggests chords, styles and percussion. The full notation is in the user guide (**F1**).

Route B: play it on the keyboard

Select the track and choose **Track... → Play with the keyboard in this track...**: play on the computer keyboard or a connected **MIDI keyboard** (dynamics, chords, sustain pedal and pitch bend), and what you play becomes text in the track, quantized to the grid you choose.

Route C: record your voice

1. **+ Add track → Audio track (vocals, guitar, keyboard)...**, name “Vocals”.
2. Click the ruler where you want to start, then the track's red ● button (or **Ctrl+R**).
3. In the dialog: **Audio interface**, **What you are recording** and **Input**. Set the gain on your interface so the loudest parts land between **−12 and −6 dB** without lighting the red clip light.
4. **Count-in (bars)** 1 or 2 bars, ● **Record**, sing, ■ **Stop**. Play it back with ▶ along with the song and, if it works, **Keep the take**: it becomes a clip in the track.

> **Recording well**
>
> To hear yourself without delay use your interface's **direct monitoring** (“direct monitor” switch or knob): SoundText sends only the song to your headphones.
>
> The first time, use **Calibrate...** in the dialog: with latency compensation the take lands exactly in time.
>
> Trim a clip by dragging its edges, split it with **S** at the playhead.

Got a recording and want the notes? **Track... → Import into this track → Audio → notation (microphone or file)...** turns a solo melody into text you then check (episode 9 of the videos).

8. Listen, fix, balance

Listening

- **Space** (or F5): Play/Pause the song; **F6**: Stop; click the ruler to jump.
- **A-B loop**: while playing, **Ctrl+[** sets the start and **Ctrl+]** the end; **Ctrl+L** turns the loop on and off. Great for working on the chorus.
- **Shift+Space**: only the selected box. The **metronome** is in the command bar, next to the **Playback speed** (slows down without changing the pitch).

Form

- Drag boxes to move them in time (they snap to the bar).
- **Ctrl+D** duplicates, **Del** deletes, right-click → **Transpose...** to transpose a box.
- To move a box to another track: right-click → Cut, then right-click the destination row → Paste here.

Balancing (the mix)

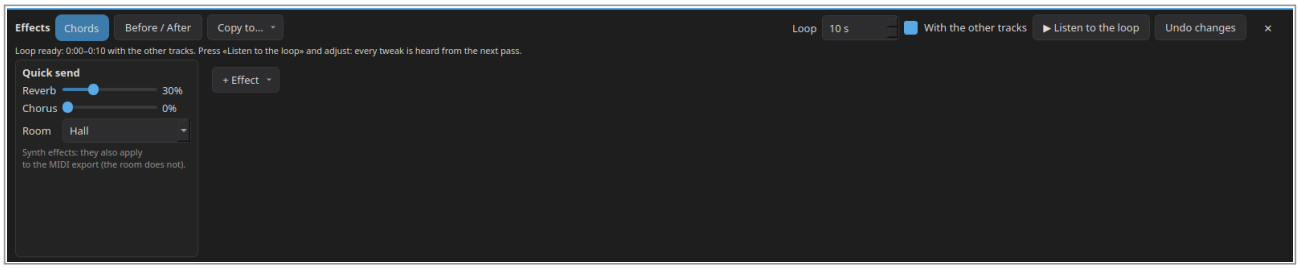
Each header has two knobs: **Vol** (0–200%, 100% = original level) and **Pan** (left/right, C = center). Drag them or use the mouse wheel; double-click to reset.

Track	Suggested volume	Suggested pan
Drums	90–100%	center
Bass	90–110%	center
Chords (piano)	70–85%	slightly left
Electric guitar	75–90%	slightly right
Vocals or melody	100–120%	center

> **Tip**
>
> Set levels **before** effects and check them again afterwards: compressor and amplifier change the perceived volume. **S** (Solo) on a track to hear it alone, **M** (Mute) to silence it.
>
> **Playback → Analyze levels...** checks the whole song and points out the tracks that clip (the Master's **CLIP** light turns on).

9. Track effects

Every track, notes or audio, has an **FX** button in its header. It opens the track's **Effects panel** at the bottom of the window. The button lights up when the track has effects and shows how many (e.g. **FX 4**).



The Effects panel of the Chords track: the “Quick send” card with reverb, chorus and room. On the right, “+ Effect” builds the chain.

Quick send (note tracks only)

Synth **Reverb** and **Chorus**, 0 to 100%, and the reverb **Room**, one for the whole song. In the default **Small room** the reverb is barely audible: for our song choose **Hall** and give the chords 20–30% reverb.

The effect chain

+ Effect adds an effect at the end of the chain; the sound flows from left to right. Each effect is a **card**:

- the **power** button (top left) bypasses it without losing the settings;
- ◀ ▶ move it in the chain, × removes it;
- the **preset** menu: pick one, then adjust the knobs;
- the **knobs**: drag them or use the mouse wheel; double-click to reset.

Family	Effects
Dynamics	Compressor, Limiter, Noise gate, Noise reduction, Volume
Tone	3-band EQ, High-pass filter, Low-pass filter
Saturation	Amplifier, NAM profile, Distortion
Space	Delay, Reverb, Chorus, Phaser
Plugin	The installed VST3 and LV2 effects (chapter 14)

The calibration loop

When the panel opens, SoundText picks a **10-second** stretch (from the selected box or the playhead) and sets it as the loop on the ruler. Press ▶ **Listen to the loop**: the stretch repeats and **every tweak is heard from the next pass**, with no waiting.

- **Loop**: 2 to 30 seconds; **With the other tracks**: hear the track in the mix (recommended) or alone;
- **Before / After**: held down, you hear the track without the chain: the most honest way to tell whether an effect really helps;
- **Undo changes**: back to how it was when the panel opened; **Copy to…**: copies the chain to another track (or the master);
- ×: closes; the previous loop comes back and the effects are applied to the whole track in the background.

Recipes for our song

Track	Suggested chain (in order)	Why
Bass	Compressor «Bass»	Steady level, more present bass
Drums	Compressor «Drums» → 3-band EQ «More presence»	Tighter and punchier
Chords	3-band EQ “More warmth” + Quick send reverb 25%, room Hall	Soft, sitting behind the vocals
Recorded vocals	High-pass filter «Vocals» → Noise gate «Vocals» → Compressor «Vocals» → 3-band EQ «More presence» → Delay «In time 1/4» → Reverb «Room»	Clean, steady, upfront, with some space
Written melody	Reverb «Hall» (mix 15–20%)	Less “fake”, more ambience

Two tips

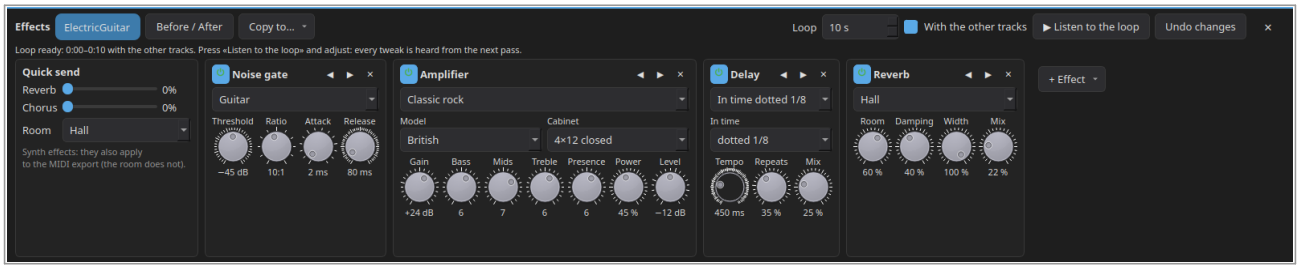
Delay in time: in the delay, the **In time** menu → 1/4, dotted 1/8... The repeats fall in time with the song's BPM; the Time knob turns off and shows the milliseconds (at 100 BPM, dotted 1/8 = 450 ms).

Few effects, done well: always check with **Before / After**.

10. The guitar amplifier

The **Amplifier** is a complete guitar amp: preamp (the distortion), tone controls and cabinet. We apply it to the ElectricGuitar track.

1. Press **FX** on the **ElectricGuitar** track.
2. **+ Effect** → **Saturation** → **Amplifier**.
3. **▶ Listen to the loop**, then choose the **Classic rock** preset (British model, closed 4×12 cabinet).
4. Complete the chain: **Noise gate** “Guitar” **before** the amp (use ◀ to move it), then **Delay** “In time dotted 1/8” and **Reverb** “Hall” **after** it.
5. Compare with **Before / After**, adjust **Level** and the track volume, close with ×.



The guitar chain: Noise gate → Amplifier (Classic rock: British, closed 4×12) → Delay in time, dotted 1/8 → Hall reverb.

Presets, models and cabinets

The presets are five starting points: Bright clean, Blues, Vintage, Classic rock, Metal. Each sets model, cabinet and knobs; then you adjust.

Model	Character	Tone stack	For
Clean	Almost no saturation	Fender	Funk, pop, arpeggios, jazz
Crunch	Soft saturation that follows your touch	Fender	Blues, light rock
British	Forward mids, two gain stages	Marshall	Classic rock, hard rock
High gain	Tight lows, lots of gain	Marshall	Metal, modern rock

Cabinet	Sound
Combo 1×12	Balanced, open: the most versatile choice
2×12	Fuller, more sculpted mids
4×12 closed	More body and low-end punch: rock and metal
Vintage 1×10	Thinner and nasal, 1950s–60s
None	The amp's direct sound, no cabinet (rarely useful)
IR file…	The impulse response of a real cabinet, from a WAV file (see below)

The knobs

- **Gain**: how much it distorts. A little = crunch, a lot = full saturation.
- **Bass, Mids, Treble** (0–10): the tone stack of real amps (Fender or Marshall, depending on the model). They interact as in the originals. To make the guitar cut through the mix raise the **Mids**, not the volume; for metal lower them (3 or less).
- **Presence** (0–10): the highs after the power stage, for air and bite.
- **Power** (0–100%): how hard the tube power stage is driven: warmth and a little compression on held chords. 30–50% is the sound of an amp played loud.
- **Level**: the output volume. More gain means more volume: lower the level as you raise the gain.

> **Secrets of a good tone**
>
> **Order matters**: noise gate → amp → delay → reverb, as on a real pedalboard.
>
> **Play with the pick, not the knob**: the amp responds to your touch. On note tracks the dynamics do the same (`p@`, `f@`).
>
> **Less gain than you think**: a very distorted sound is impressive alone, but turns to mush in the mix. In a chorus with drums and bass, Crunch is often enough.

A real amplifier: NAM profiles

Neural Amp Modeler (NAM) “captures” a real amp or pedal with a neural network: the result is a **profile**, a `.nam` file, that reproduces its sound very faithfully. SoundText uses them with the **NAM profile** effect, on Linux, Windows and macOS.

1. **Sounds → Download and install...**, category **Guitar amplifiers (NAM)**: tick **Recommended NAM profiles** (34 famous amps and pedals) and **IR cabinets for NAM amplifiers** (20 cabinets), then **Install**.
2. In the guitar chain: **+ Effect → Saturation → NAM profile** and choose the profile. The card shows its name, brand, model and author.
3. If the profile is a head without a cabinet, **Cabinet** menu → **IR file…** and pick one of the downloaded cabinets; if the cabinet is included (or it's a pedal), leave **None / included**.
4. **Input** sets how hard you drive the profile, **Level** the output. Remove (or bypass) the built-in Amplifier: the profile replaces it.

Good to know

SoundText brings every profile to the same reference loudness, so switching profiles doesn't make the volume jump.

On Linux and Windows (x64) the same category offers the **Fast NAM engine (Neural Amp Modeler plugin)**: profiles are computed 4–6 times faster.

Thousands more free profiles are on **Tone3000** (tone3000.com): filter by NAM and type (*amp*, *full rig*, *pedal*) and extract the .nam files into the profiles folder.

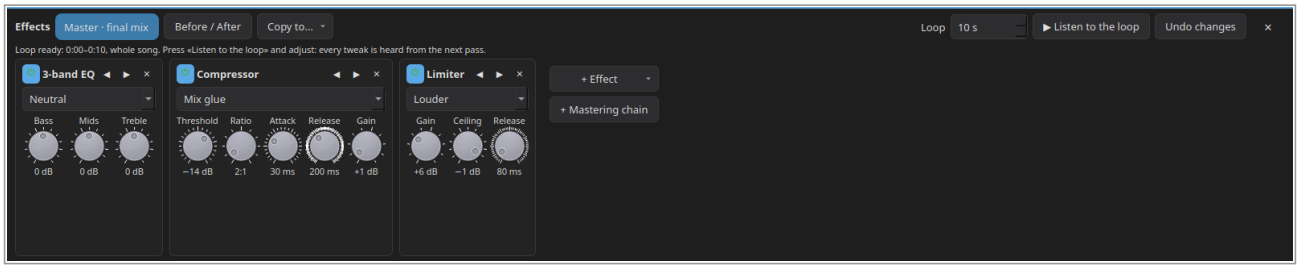
11. Mastering

Mastering is the final touch on the whole mix: it makes it tighter, more balanced and loud enough to sit next to other songs. In SoundText it's done with the effect chain on the **Master**.



The Master row, at the bottom of the track column: FX, volume and level meter.

1. Click the ruler at the start of the **chorus** (the loudest part of the song): the calibration loop starts from the playhead.
2. Press **FX** in the **Master** row: the panel opens on **Master · final mix**.
3. Press **+ Mastering chain**: you get **3-band EQ** “Neutral”, **Compressor** “Mix glue” and **Limiter** “Louder”.
4. **▶ Listen to the loop** and compare with **Before / After**.
5. Set the limiter's **Gain**: higher = louder, more squashed song. Stop when the drums lose their punch. The **Ceiling** stays at −1 dB.
6. If needed, small EQ touches (±1–3 dB). Close with ×.



The mastering chain: EQ, “Mix glue” compressor (2:1, slow attack) and “Louder” limiter (ceiling −1 dB).

Two traps

With **Before / After** the “after” is louder, and ears always think louder is better. For an honest comparison, lower the limiter gain until both sound about equally loud.

The **Master** volume acts **before** the chain: with the limiter on, raising it doesn't make the song louder past the ceiling, it only squashes it.

12. Exporting the WAV

1. Save the project (**Ctrl+S**) and listen to the whole song one last time from the start.
2. **Project → Export → Audio mix (WAV)...**
3. Choose name and folder (the project name is suggested) and confirm.

The file is a **stereo WAV at 48 kHz, 24 bit**, studio quality. It contains the song **as you hear it**: only the audible tracks (it follows Mute and Solo), the audio tracks, every track effect, the amplifier and the master chain.

Export	Where	Effects	Master
Song mix (WAV)	**Project → Export → Audio mix (WAV)...**	yes	yes
All tracks, one WAV each (stems)	**Project → Export → All tracks, one file each (stems)...**	yes	no
A single track (WAV)	**Track... → Export this track → WAV...**	yes	no
MIDI	**Project → Export → MIDI...**	synth reverb and chorus only	no
Score	**Project → Export → PDF score...**, **MusicXML score...**	—	—

Watch out

Before exporting, check that no track was left in **Solo** or **Mute** by mistake: the WAV follows them.

After the export

To publish as MP3 or AAC, convert the WAV with a dedicated program (Audacity, ffmpeg...): starting from the 24-bit WAV gives the best quality.

Stems (one track per file, no master) are for whoever will mix the song in another program. MusicXML takes the score into MuseScore and other notation programs (episode 13).

13. Studio sounds with other programs

For a studio sound the easiest route is the **NAM profile** (chapter 10). Alternatively you can run the track through an external amp simulator and bring it back into the song. This is **re-amping**: you record the clean guitar once and can change amp whenever you like, without playing the part again.

The workflow, on any system

1. Record the **clean** guitar on an audio track (**INST/Hi-Z** input, no amp) or write it as notes (chapter 6).
2. Select the track and choose **Track... → Export this track → Dry WAV (for re-amping)...**. The file comes out without effects, panned center and without the master; it starts at the beginning of the song, so it stays in time.
3. In the external program apply the simulator to the file and save the result as a new WAV.
4. In SoundText create an audio track (e.g. “Amped guitar”) and choose **Track... → Import into this track → Audio file as a clip (audio track)...**: on an empty track the clip goes to the start, in time with the song.
5. **Mute** the original track, or keep both and blend clean and amped with the volumes.

Free programs for re-amping

Program	What it is	Systems
Guitarix	Simulated tube amps and pedals, with cabinets and IRs. Also as LV2 plugins (`guitarix-lv2`), usable directly inside SoundText.	Linux
Neural Amp Modeler	The plugin and app for .nam profiles: useful for playing live (profiles already work inside SoundText).	Windows, macOS
AIDA-X	Similar to NAM and lighter. Plugin and standalone app.	Windows, macOS, Linux
Audacity	Opens the dry WAV, applies a plugin (VST3, LV2, AU) and exports.	Windows, macOS, Linux

Package names and menu items of external programs can change between versions: when in doubt, check their documentation.

14. VST3 and LV2 plugins, SFZ instruments

Besides the built-in effects and SoundFonts, SoundText uses the **audio plugins installed on your computer**: virtual instruments that play a track's notes instead of the SoundFont, and effects for a track's or the master's chain. **VST3** plugins work (Linux, Windows, macOS) and, on Linux, **LV2**, each in its own process. CLAP and VST2 are not supported.

To get started, **Sounds → Download and install... → Free plugins and programs** installs a selection of free plugins in your user folder: Surge XT, Dexed, Dragonfly Reverb, Airwindows Consolidated, OB-Xf and more, depending on the system.

A virtual instrument on a track

1. SoundText looks for VST3 plugins in the standard folders; add others in **Sounds → VST3 plugin folders...**
2. Select the track (for example “Chords”) and choose **Track... → Plugin instrument → Choose (VST3/LV2)...**, or right-click the track name.
3. Pick the instrument from the list. The first time, SoundText loads each plugin to find out what it is: it may take a while, then the list is remembered.
4. The **parameters** window opens (with many parameters use **Search for a parameter…**), or open **Plugin interface…** to use its own window and presets. Press **OK**.
5. Press **Play**: the track plays through the plugin. The track's volume, pan and effects apply as usual.

> **Tip**
> To go back to the SoundFont: **None: use the SoundFont** in the same list.
> A large plugin takes a few seconds to load the first time it plays: after that, playback starts right away.

SFZ sampled instruments

SFZ instruments are pianos, guitars, basses, strings and drums sampled from real instruments: they sound far more realistic than the General MIDI SoundFont.

1. In **Sounds → Download and install...** tick the instruments you need (**Sampled instruments (SFZ)**) and, under **Engines**, the built-in SFZ engine: it is compiled on your computer in a few minutes (it needs git, cmake and a compiler; the window offers to install them).
2. **Track... → Plugin instrument → Choose (VST3/LV2)... → SFZ instrument (built-in)…** and choose the instrument's .sfz file.

A plugin as an effect

In the track's Effects panel (chapter 9): **+ Effect → Plugin → Plugin (VST3/LV2)** and choose the effect. The card has **Mix** and **Level** knobs: tweaks are heard right away in the listening loop, as with the built-in effects.

> **If something goes wrong**
> If a plugin hangs or crashes, SoundText stays open: the plugin is marked as “not responding” until the next start. A failing effect lets the sound through unchanged; a track whose plugin instrument fails plays with the SoundFont.

15. The menu map (SoundText 1.14)

Where to find what we used, and a few more things.

Menu	What you'll find
Project	New, Open, Open example..., Save; Import (MIDI, MusicXML, ABC, MTXT); Export (WAV mix, stems, MIDI, PDF score, MusicXML, ABC, MTXT).
Edit	Undo and Redo; delete and duplicate the box; split the audio clip at the playhead.
View	Song structure (boxes), Score... (Ctrl+Shift+P), zoom, track height, text size.
Track...	Add (also with a virtual instrument or audio), plugin instrument, import and export the track, record, play with the keyboard.
Compose	Generate drums, bass, progression, comping; Arrange the song...; your own styles; pattern and MIDI libraries; key analysis.
Playback	Play, Stop, A-B loop, listening speed, humanize, Analyze levels....
Sounds	Manage instruments..., SoundFont, synth volume, VST3 plugin folders, Download and install...
Options	Metronome, humanize, download sources, MIDI and audio import, theme, language.
Help	Search for a command... (Ctrl+K), User guide... (F1), the log file, about.

The video tutorials

Each chapter of this guide has a matching episode in the YouTube series (English, with subtitles in Italian, French and Spanish): youtube.com/playlist?list=PLbVfXEqrD3P4

Episode	Topic	Chapters
1	Installing SoundText	2
2	Getting the sounds	2, 14
3	Writing music as text	7
4	From chords to an arrangement	4, 5
5	The song structure	3, 8
6	Playing with the computer keyboard	7
7	Chords, voicings and harmony	4
8	Audio tracks	7, 13
9	From sound to notation	7
10	Sampled instruments (SFZ)	14
11	Effects and plugins	9, 11, 14
12	Guitars with NAM profiles	10
13	Exporting	12

16. Checklist and common problems

Before exporting

	Check
☐	The song starts and ends cleanly (drum ending, long last chord)
☐	No track left in Solo or Mute by mistake
☐	Levels balanced: the vocal/melody is clear, the bass is audible even at low volume
☐	Effects checked with Before / After: each one really improves something
☐	Master: limiter with a −1 dB ceiling, drums not squashed; the CLIP light stays off
☐	Project saved (Ctrl+S)

Common problems

Problem	Solution
No sound at all	The SoundFont is missing: **Sounds → SoundFont → Show SoundFont in use** shows which one is used and, if none, offers to download one. Also check the tracks aren't muted.
“Bass from chords...” is greyed out	The song has no chord track yet: generate one (chapter 4).
The guitar sounds muddy	Too much gain or an already distorted GM sound: use Electric Guitar (clean) and less gain.
The exported WAV is distorted	Too loud: **Playback → Analyze levels...** points out the clipping tracks; lower them or put the limiter on the master.
The recording is out of time	In the recording dialog use Calibrate... once per audio interface.
Something doesn't work	**Help → Open the log file** shows the errors the program logged: they often explain the cause right away.
I made a mistake	Ctrl+Z undoes any change, effects included.

Shortcuts to remember

Key	Action	Key	Action
Space / F5	Play / Pause	Ctrl+N / Ctrl+S	New / Save
Shift+Space	Play the selected box	Ctrl+T	Add track
F6	Stop	Ctrl+R	Record
Ctrl+[/ Ctrl+]	Loop start / end	Ctrl+Z / Ctrl+Y	Undo / Redo
Ctrl+L	Loop on/off	Ctrl+K	Find a command
Ctrl+D	Duplicate the box	Ctrl+Shift+B	Structure / Text view
Del	Delete the box	Ctrl+Shift+P	Score
S	Split the clip at the playhead	F1	User guide

For every detail there's the full user guide: **Help → User guide...** (F1). Enjoy making music!